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A door always opens.



Dear reader,

By the time this issue of "inform" reaches you, the year will almost be over. But as I write this editorial, two major events are still pending. In September, Drinktec in Munich will bring the entire PET industry together and we will showcase the new PET Series 320 from our sister company Otto Systems. And then, in October, we'll be at the K trade fair in Düsseldorf, where we will be celebrating the 70th anniversary of Otto Hofstetter AG in a stand designed for relaxed conversations, so do drop in.

The K trade fair will conclude our anniversary celebrations, which have been most rewarding. At gatherings with our em-

ployees, with the people of Uznach and with our partners, the many friendly and welcoming encounters have shown us that our entrepreneurial partnerships have not only enabled a successful past, they also point to our continuing success.

That said, the challenges aren't diminishing. Geopolitical upheavals and the intensifying trade restrictions are keeping us busy these days. Markets where we have worked with loyal customers for years are no longer accessible to us. And if these challenges weren't enough, the strong Swiss franc and the tariffs imposed on Swiss products by the Trump administration are also giving us headaches.

In times like these, it's good to have a long company history to look back on. Sure enough, there have been earlier moments when external factors hampered the company's development. But our success over the decades shows that as long as you stick to your values, cultivate your strengths and meet new challenges with creativity and resolve, solutions do emerge and new doors do open. And, crucially for us, we have been able to count on our many loyal customers and our committed employees. Together, we will also weather the current choppy seas, I'm sure.

Returning to the present, in the new issue of "inform", we profile SanQua Water, based in Jakarta, whose products enjoy a high reputation in Indonesia. And Taipei is home to Long Thames, which has been supplying the Taiwanese market with various plastic packaging since 1971. And when it comes to loyalty, our colleague Andrea Kuster is a role model. We introduce her to you in this issue, too.

As you can see, we have assembled some worthwhile reading material in the latest issue of "inform". I hope you enjoy it. And I hope to meet you in person, either at the upcoming trade shows or in the course of Otto Hofstetter AG's 71st year.

Wishing you every success,
Stefan Zatti

Imprint.

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Size alone is not the goal.

With a hundred dollars in his pocket, Tanto Hariyadi founded SanQua in 1996. Today, this Indonesian water company employs nearly 3,000 people and is one of the most important companies in the industry. The business extends from preform production to filling and distribution, and Tanto Hariyadi knows every step in all of its processes in detail. In this interview, he explains why trust is the foundation of all business success.

Mr Hariyadi, I heard that you founded your company in 1996 with only a hundred dollars in start-up capital. What prompted you to take this step?

I have to back up a bit. I studied in the United States. Since my father had clear expectations regarding his support, I worked while studying or had friends advance my tuition, and after two and a half years, I graduated. That was a valuable lesson in self-reliance.

After graduating, I returned to Indonesia. I had a hundred dollars in my pocket and a simple but clear vision in my mind: drinking water is a basic need, the population is growing rapidly and the public water supply system cannot meet demand. If I have production, quality, waste and efficiency under control, something great can happen. Marketing wasn't the starting point. I built the company from the production perspective, focusing on processes, productivity, material usage and reliable delivery. That was my path, and it still shapes us today.

**"IF I HAVE PRODUCTION,
QUALITY, WASTE AND EFFICIENCY
UNDER CONTROL, SOMETHING
GREAT CAN HAPPEN."**

Tanto Hariyadi, founder and CEO of SanQua

What were the biggest hurdles you had to overcome?

The biggest test came with the crisis of 1998 and 1999. Exchange rates and material prices exploded, supply chains stalled and many companies could no longer meet their obligations. I procured raw materials in cash at the spot price and offered customers a prepayment discount. This kept the material flow stable and commitments were met. At the same time, I analysed every operational metric, from the waste rates to energy consumption to warehouse routes. If necessary, I stood at the machines through the night. This discipline carried us through that difficult time. Whoever creates stability first, survives. Growth only follows afterwards.

This was when I developed the habit of calculating every detail. How many steps does a change in the process require and how much time does it take? What does cutting a tenth of a second in the cycle bring us? Where do we lose material and where do we lose time? This way of thinking still shapes our actions today.

Your father was also in the water business. Why did you start your own company anyway?

My father had a different philosophy of business. He was a trader for most of his life. For me, the water business is an industrial challenge, with the need for continuous investment and the obligation to continuously develop processes and people.

I also wanted to be able to make independent decisions, bear risks myself and create my own success. This also follows my attitude towards succession. Success cannot be inherited. I hold the same view with my children. Should they one day decide to continue my company, they will have to buy it from me. I will show them how it's done, but then I will step back. Only then can they do "their own thing" and celebrate their own successes.

Twenty-nine years have now passed since the company was founded. What does SanQua look like today?

We currently employ 2,878 people. Our business model covers the entire value chain, from pre-forms to blow moulding and filling to distribution. Our preform capacity is around 160 million units, and we're naturally in the same range for closures. For a long time, we produced large quantities of water cups, but the market has shifted toward PET bottles. Today, the small bottle segment is growing significantly faster, both for our brand and in partnerships.

Proximity to the market is crucial to our success. After our first water production facility in Cinere started in 1996, plants followed in Tapos, Citeureup, Cibinong, Kuningan, Bawen and next year in Banyuwangi and Pasuruan. In 2014, we founded the distribution company PT Wahana Inti Mas in Jakarta. This production network allows us to better manage schedules and costs, boosting efficiency while supporting just-in-time delivery and minimising inventory levels.

How has the water business developed in Indonesia, and what trends are you observing?

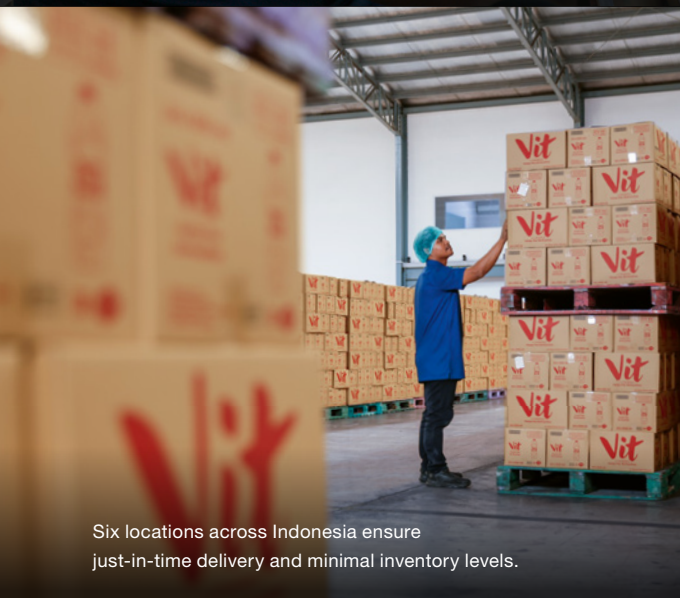
The market is growing from a low base. In Southeast Asia, per capita PET consumption is still considered low. According to our data, we are at about one-third of Thailand's level. With increasing purchasing power and greater awareness of water quality, demand is shifting from cups to small-format PET bottles. Therefore, we see substantial potential to diversify our product offerings and better meet evolving market needs.

Is the use of rPET an issue in Indonesia?

We are committed to expanding recycling initiatives within our company; however, we have no plans to use recycled PET (rPET) in applications where packaging comes into direct contact with food or beverages. I see strong potential for non-food applications, such as pallets or other components. However,



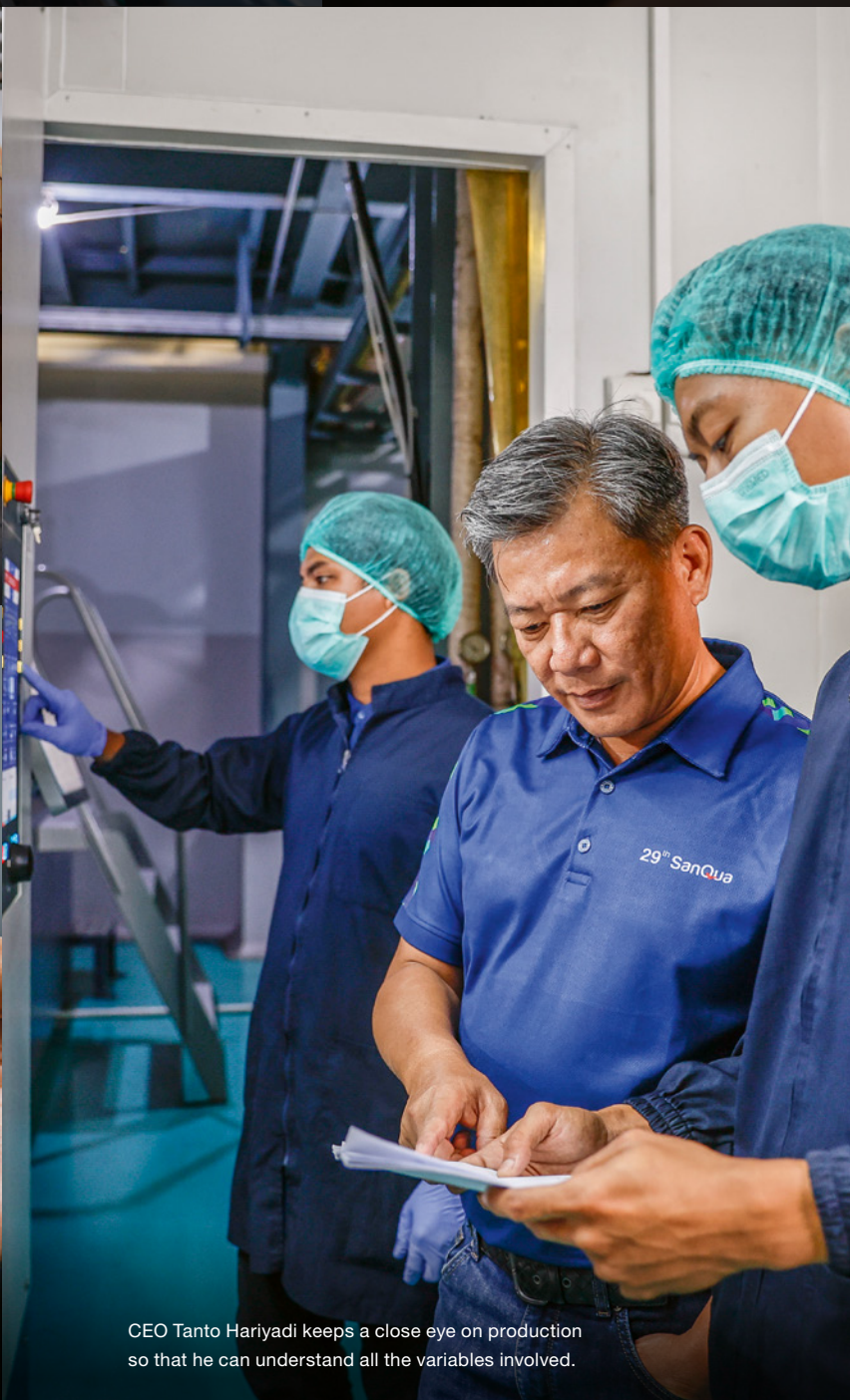
With nearly 3,000 employees, SanQua covers the entire value chain from preforms to filling and distribution.



Six locations across Indonesia ensure just-in-time delivery and minimal inventory levels.



We used to produce large quantities of water cups at SanQua but our preform capacity, currently at around 160 million units, is now growing faster.



CEO Tanto Hariyadi keeps a close eye on production so that he can understand all the variables involved.

for any packaging that comes into direct contact with food or beverages, I will continue to use virgin materials until the quality of recycled materials is fully assured.

Your customers include renowned brands like Danone. Why do they choose SanQua?

We consistently deliver on Danone's expectations in terms of volume, product quality, service excellence, cost competitiveness and continuous improvement. We also regularly undergo quality audits. In the beginning, they challenged us. Today, they support us in continuously improving our processes, food safety and reliability. The mechanism is simple: good performance is rewarded with volume, while poor performance generates headwinds. This creates a virtuous circle of ambition and trust. Overall, we operate at a level that meets international benchmarks.

We hear that you can still operate every machine today. Why is staying so close to production important to you?

Theoretically, yes, but I stay out of the day-to-day business. On the other hand, all developments and investments pass my desk. I want to understand every system, from setup to target cycle time and compressed air window to the cost per carton. Once a quarter, I dig deep into the numbers. If a production line light turns red, I'm heading to the production hall.

It's not about assigning blame. I want to understand the root cause so that a suitable solution can be found. This proximity contributes to my credibility, binds the team and has a direct impact on staff turnover, which is below 0.01 per cent. That's not an advertising slogan, but the result of respect, clear goals and a fair share in the company's success. It's all about trust. The factories budget on their own. Once I approve the budget, management returns entirely to them.

You question many technical issues internally. What motivates you to do this?

Success requires a deep understanding of every variable. We calculate the full cost of our process – from raw materials to final delivery to the end consumer – because we believe customers shouldn't bear the burden of inefficiencies. This mindset drives clarity in decision-making and creates competitive advantages in our daily operations.

What requirements do you have for mould technology, and which aspects are particularly important?

Stability and repeatability are more important to me than theoretical maximum values on a data sheet. A mould that theoretically manages 2,000 cycles per hour but stops after two hours is no use to me. I need robust processes, low shot



"STABILITY AND REPEATABILITY
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MAXIMUM VALUES
ON A DATA SHEET."

Tanto Hariyadi, founder and CEO of SanQua

weights, low scrap rates and interfaces that don't restrict me. I fundamentally reject technical locks that shut down machines based on licences, passwords or IP. Trust doesn't develop when systems are stopped simply because contracts expire. What we need are open and powerful systems that enable continuous production. If our calculations no longer work, we are also prepared to invest in new equipment.

What did you know about Otto Hofstetter AG before you contacted their people?

Otto Hofstetter AG's reputation is well-known throughout the industry. For me, it was crucial to learn that they actually listen to prospective customers and discuss solutions, not just push their products. Unfortunately, that's not always the case. Other suppliers try to bind their customers through proprietary systems. That's not a basis for a trusting collaboration. At Otto Hofstetter AG, I experienced openness, professional exchange and respect for our needs. Even if there's no order pending, we receive useful information. This creates a foundation on which projects can be set up smoothly and jointly supported.

In 2024, you purchased your first 96-cavity side-entry mould from Otto Hofstetter. What led to this decision?

The relationship had been established for some time – always

professional, never pressured. When the timing was right, the options presented aligned with our goals for quality, performance and service. As I don't rely solely on data sheets, the first mould had to validate what the paper claimed. If it delivered, the next steps would follow naturally. This kind of trust isn't built in a year, but through time and transparency.

Otto Hofstetter AG is the only supplier to use the Cavity Lock system for its moulds. What do you see as its advantages?

The precise guidance and secure centring of the cavities increases precision, reduces wear and enables shorter cycle times. When considering alternative locking systems, service life, reliability and the effect on the process window were crucial for us. In the end, what matters is how smoothly the demoulding process runs and how stable the weights remain. This is precisely the standard I use to evaluate such a system.

How did you experience the process from initial discussions to startup?

It was streamlined, clear and accessible. There's no additional reporting line or process involvement, which only results in responsibility being partially delegated to too many people. This simplified communication avoids misunderstandings, acceptance procedures run smoothly and contacts are available when needed. Otto Hofstetter AG is lean and therefore effective.

The 96-cavity side-entry mould from Uznach has been running for several months now. What's your interim assessment?

The mould is running smoothly and preform quality is consistent. There have been no unexpected incidents during bottle blowing or demoulding so far. The reject rate during blowing and filling remains at our low level or even slightly lower. Overall, our productivity remains stable or is even increasing. This is exactly what I expect from a mould that is part of a complete production chain. Our advantage is that we can see the entire process, from preforming to blowing to filling, and can make adjustments throughout the entire process.

How would you rate the service and support provided by the Otto Hofstetter AG team?

Since the mould has only been running for a few months, I can't yet look back on a very long collaboration. So far, Otto Hofstetter AG's team has been very reliable and knowledgeable. Topics are shared proactively, even if there is no immediate order pending. This type of support reduces my operational





SanQua prefers the Cavity Lock system made by Otto Hofstetter AG because it ensures precision, reduces wear and secures reliable long-term performance.

risk. It also builds trust because you don't feel like it's all about getting the order done quickly. For me, it's crucial that I talk to people who listen to me and offer solutions.

Where do you see potential for optimising collaboration?

I'll have to really think about that. Perhaps it would be interesting to define common standards for process and quality data so that the learning curve in our company can be a bit

**"IT'S IMPORTANT FOR ME TO
TALK TO PEOPLE WHO
REALLY LISTEN AND WHO CAN
OFFER SOLID SOLUTIONS."**

Tanto Hariyadi, founder and CEO of SanQua

steeper. Furthermore, forward-looking spare parts planning for peak times could prove valuable. And more investment by Otto Hofstetter AG in remote diagnostics would make sense, too. However, only as long as it doesn't impose any restrictions on us as plant operators. I welcome openness, but I strictly reject restrictions. That's my philosophy.

What should a company pay attention to when investing in a new mould?

Fundamentally, every company and every task is different. Generally speaking, they should clearly define their goals and openly address any problems they may have. It's important to buy a proven solution and not settle for data sheets. Testing whether the mould actually performs in a company's existing

system is essential. Furthermore, it's advisable to ensure fairness and avoid becoming vendor-dependent. If the vendor listens and is present during commissioning, that's a good sign.

Where do you see SanQua in five to seven years?

Size is not an end in itself. Indonesia is growing, and so is our market. We're aiming for around ten per cent in Java. We're not wasting our energy trying to take market share away from competitors, but rather growing with the market. Nationally, we currently have a share of around three per cent, and in Java, six to seven per cent. Our focus is on asserting ourselves in the market, delivering reliably and being ready when opportunities arise. If others act inefficiently, we're ready to step in. That's why we keep our production and supply chain robust, invest closely with the market and remain capable of acting.

What advice do you give young people who start out with limited resources?

First, it's essential to build confidence and understand the numbers inside out: every metre, every gram, every kilowatt hour matters. A lean organisation and consistent reinvestment of profits are key to long-term resilience. In the early stages, opportunity takes precedence and risk is secondary. But once a company is operating smoothly and accountable to both employees and customers, that balance shifts – caution becomes critical in major decisions, while courage is needed in daily execution. This approach ensures stability and preserves the freedom to act decisively.

Mr Hariyadi, thank you very much for this open discussion. We wish you every success in implementing your plans, and we look forward to continuing our journey together.



sanquawater.com

Founded: 1996
Products: Mineral water and carbonated beverages
Locations: Tapos, Citeureup, Cibinong, Kuningan and Bawen, Indonesia

Jalan Bintaro Permai No. 26, RT.6/RW.9, Bintaro, Kec. Pesanggrahan, Kota Jakarta Selatan, Daerah Khusus Ibukota Jakarta 12330, Indonesia



More than a label.

When you see the **Swiss cross on a product**, you automatically expect **quality and reliability**. But not every Swiss product meets these expectations. In fact, **true “Swissness” involves multiple criteria**, including the one that counts the most: how it satisfies the customer in daily use.

One of our customers once put it succinctly: just because a product comes from Switzerland doesn't mean it automatically clears the high bar of Swiss quality. Customers around the world associate "Swiss Made" with strong performance but a label alone is far from sufficient. For Otto Hofstetter AG, Swissness is the totality of several important factors. Yes, the product itself should meet the highest standards of quality, but it should also be delivered on time and the customer should be impeccably supported after the purchase. For us, Swissness isn't just a label, it's a commitment.

Definition with substance.

There are some very clearly defined legal standards that must be met for a product to carry the "Swiss Made" label. For industrial products, for example, at least 60 per cent of the manufacturing costs must be incurred in Switzerland, and the most important manufacturing steps must also take place there. These criteria apply not only to the goods themselves. Any company wishing to use the designation "Swiss Made" in advertising must be able to prove that this claim has been earned.

And satisfying these criteria can be a bit complicated, since the Swiss customs authorities have their own definition of what makes a product Swiss. This also includes a proof of origin, but they use a different formula. For example, the customs authorities also consider the manufacturer's profit margin, whereas with "Swiss Made", only actual manufacturing costs incurred in Switzerland are considered, as well as determining that the most important manufacturing steps take place in the country. Thus, something may be considered a Swiss product for customs purposes but does not qualify for the "Swiss Made" label.

Trust instead of surveillance.

"Made in Switzerland" is a valuable badge for a manufacturer, but, perhaps surprisingly, this status is not monitored by a licensing or inspection authority. The responsibility for its legal use lies solely with the companies. That said, there is a range of legal remedies, as well as administrative measures, that can be undertaken against unjustified use of the "Swiss Made" label. The Federal Institute of Intellectual Property can take action in Switzerland in cases of obvious misuse. Abroad, the Institute monitors trademark registers and files objections to misleading applications. It also works with authorities to prevent deceptive use of the Swiss cross or the designation "Switzerland".

**"SWISS MADE IS THE INTERPLAY
OF PRECISE MANUFACTURING
AND CUSTOMER-
ORIENTED BEHAVIOUR."**



Swissness has multiple dimensions.

Around the world, Swissness is understood not only to mean precision and high quality, but also durability, reliability and safety. There is also an ethical dimension to Swissness in terms of corporate conduct.

For Otto Hofstetter AG, "Swiss Made" includes precision manufacturing as well as customer-first support. Our moulds are manufactured almost entirely in Uznach, and our suppliers also produce primarily in Switzerland. We only source raw steel and a small number of components from neighbouring countries. With this local added value, Otto Hofstetter AG far exceeds the legal requirements for "Swiss Made" products.

The way we conduct our business is also typically Swiss. Deadlines are met, communication is clear and proactive, and a spirit of respectful cooperation is always maintained. This also ap-



plies to customer support. For example, since our moulds often stay in service a very long time, Otto Hofstetter AG maintains a stock of spare parts for many years. Our Swiss-style service team responds quickly and efficiently, too. This is evident from the first acceptance tests, through commissioning, to routine maintenance and service calls.

Everyday benefits.

Manufacturers of PET preforms, packaging and medical parts enjoy a variety of benefits from the uncompromising Swissness of our family-owned business. The rigorous quality of our moulds ensures greater process stability, which translates into smoother processing downstream of the mould. Parts manufactured with our moulds function flawlessly. "Swiss Made" also translates into minimal downtime. Our robust, durable moulds and our dedicated, fast-track service support assure maximum system availability. And when maintenance can be scheduled reliably, delivery commitments are not jeopardised by unexpected downtime.

"SWISSNESS IS NOT JUST A DECORATION— IT IS A COMMITMENT."

The proverbial longevity attributed to Swiss products is epitomised by the moulds from Otto Hofstetter AG, which can achieve up to 20 million cycles before any maintenance is needed, allowing them to run smoothly for ten years or more.

"Swiss Made" also helps with compliance issues. Our moulds consistently maintain their precisely defined geometry and surface finish over extended periods of time. This allows

manufacturers of medical devices and food packaging to meet the highest quality requirements.

And, last but not least, PET manufacturers using moulds made in Switzerland by Otto Hofstetter AG can credibly demonstrate to their customers that their products are of the highest quality and that their production is exceptionally reliable. Thus, quality begets quality all along the production chain. That's what Otto Hofstetter AG's "Swiss Made" status really delivers.



David Chen is following in the footsteps of his father and grandfather and will lead the family business, Long Thames, into the future.

Long Thames Enterprise was founded in 1971 and is now headquartered in Bali, near Taipei, Taiwan. This family-owned company serves customers worldwide. It specialises in cartridges for silicone and grease, closures for various applications and food packaging. David Chen, a member of the family's third generation, explains in the interview how family values and long-term partnerships drive Long Thames's growth.

Letting success happen.

Long Thames was founded in 1971. What does the company look like today?

Long Thames has its main production facility in Taiwan, covering approximately 8,600 square metres, with around 30 employees. We specialise in silicone cartridges, closures and food packaging. Earlier this year, we opened a warehouse in the United States and we are planning a production facility there as well.

What were the company's early years like?

When my grandfather founded the company over 50 years ago, we were in the metal stamping business. Working with metal plates and simple machines was very dangerous, which is why my father and uncle wanted to give up these activities. They recognised that plastics offered great potential, since at that time many of their customers still filled their silicone into paper tubes.

What motivated them to enter the plastics industry in 1985?

Most of the packaging used in the market was outdated and they saw that it could be made more durable, more functional and more economical with plastic solutions. This move enabled

the company to evolve from a traditional metal stamping operation into a future-oriented plastics company.

What role does the entrepreneurial spirit of the founders still play today?

For us, the company has always been more than just a workplace – it's like a big family. I grew up in the company, surrounded by colleagues who were like uncles and aunts to me. When the company relocated, most of the employees came with

us. This family-like bond is at the heart of our entrepreneurial spirit. Internally, we care for each other beyond work. Externally, we treat customers and suppliers with integrity and we often build trust over shared meals.

"FOR US, THE COMPANY HAS ALWAYS BEEN MORE THAN JUST A WORKPLACE – IT'S LIKE A BIG FAMILY."

David Chen, CEO of Long Thames Enterprise

What makes Long Thames resilient?

For over fifty years, we've overcome challenges such as raw materials price fluctuations, international competition and many industry changes. Three factors have helped us succeed: our commitment to quality, our integrity in our relationships with our customers and partners, and our adaptability. We often joke that we "bribe" our customers with our sincerity and good cheer. In our culture, sharing a meal together is the most authentic way to build a relationship.

What does the current product portfolio look like?

Our portfolio includes silicone cartridges, grease cartridges, closures for chemical applications and other packaging products for chemicals and food products. We develop all our products with a focus on durability, functionality and user-friendliness. At the same time, we continuously invest in modern equipment and we exercise strict quality control.

**"OUR COMMITMENT TO QUALITY,
OUR INTEGRITY AND OUR
ADAPTABILITY HAVE MADE
US RESILIENT."**

David Chen, CEO of Long Thames Enterprise

Which markets are your products found in?

In addition to Taiwan, our products are distributed worldwide – from the coldest regions of Canada and Russia to the hottest climates of the Middle East. This demonstrates the ability of our products to perform consistently under widely varying conditions and underscores our commitment to quality.

What changes have you seen since the Covid pandemic?

The global market has become highly volatile, and competition has intensified. Freight costs remain high, creating new challenges. In response, we are pursuing localised production to serve customers more directly, shorten supply chain cycles and reduce the impact of market uncertainty.

How do you collaborate across cultures?

Integrity is not only a commitment within our team, but also a fundamental principle in our dealings with customers and partners. Even when working across cultures, relationships and trust are more important to us than pure profit. Open and substantial communication is the true foundation for lasting cooperation. That's why many customers have been working with us for decades.

What is motivating the expansion into the US?

It is no secret that Taiwan is under geopolitical pressure. Following the pandemic, we sensed our customers' concerns about the stability of future supplies. Although we have operated under these conditions for decades, we cannot ignore our customers' concerns. The US will be our most important strategic market and a pivotal step in our global expansion.

What is your vision for Long Thames Texas?

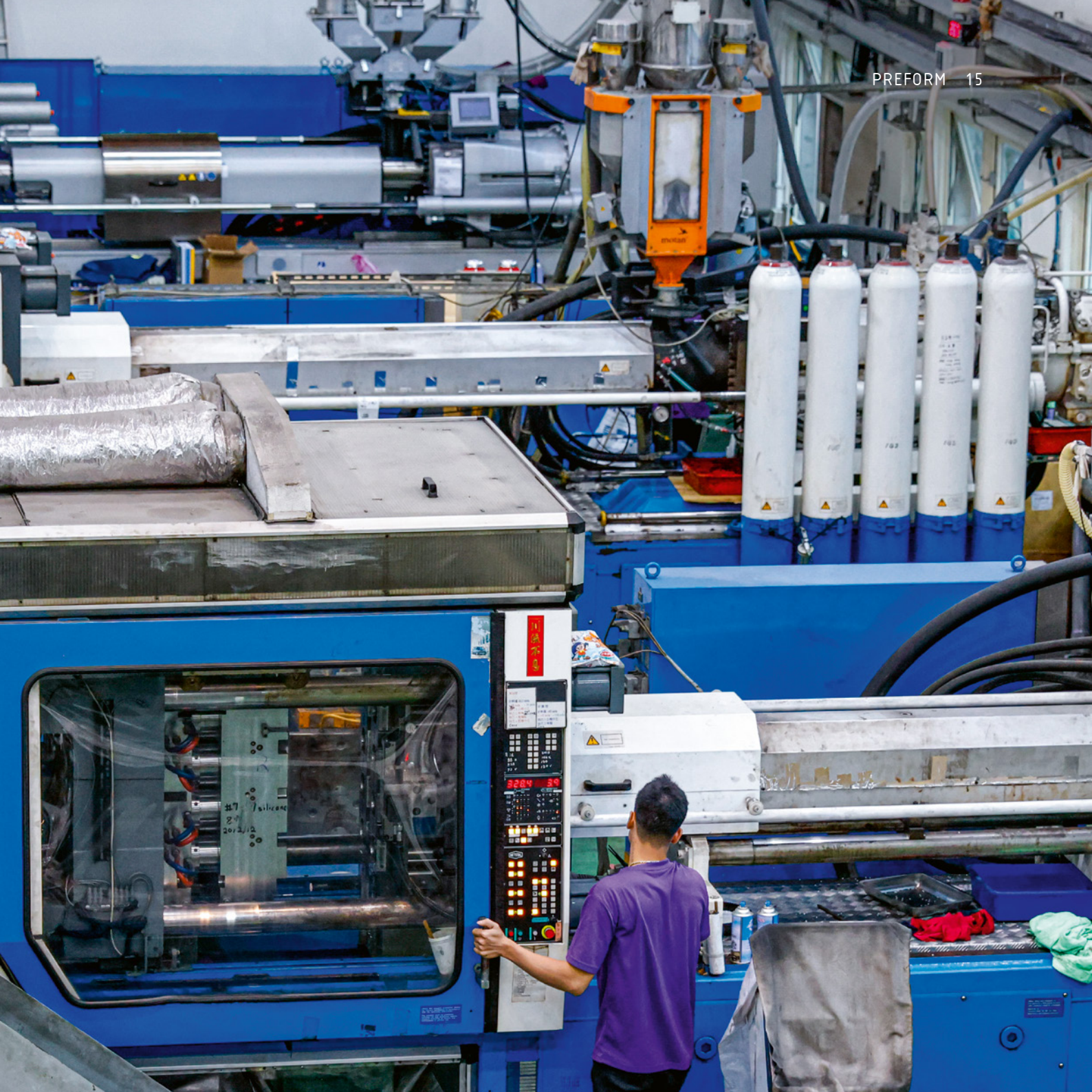
Long Thames Texas represents a significant step in our global



strategy. We are creating a holistic structure there that will support future production. We combine assembly, warehousing and localised services. Initially, we will focus on silicone and grease cartridges and other chemical packaging. With multiple injection moulding machines and a high level of automation, we will build efficient production lines and transfer our 40 years of expertise from Taiwan to the US. Long Thames Texas will also serve as our gateway to the entire Americas.

Why do customers choose Long Thames?

We focus on uncompromising quality and on continuously



Long Thames focuses on durability, functionality and user-friendliness in its products, which is why it uses modern equipment and strict quality control.

creating value, making us indispensable to our customers. In a competitive market, there will always be someone offering lower prices. However, what keeps customers loyal in the long term is reliability, consistency and added value. Relationships and trust are most important, not profit. We want our customers to feel that working with us is a long-term partnership built on trust and mutual growth.

Why do you invest in high-quality machines?

When we first switched from Taiwanese-made machines to European equipment, there was some internal scepticism

due to the higher investment. In the long term, however, these machines have delivered consistently better quality, greater production efficiency and lower scrap rates. This outcome reflects well on our decision to focus on quality over price. We are convinced this approach is the key to long-term success.

How did the collaboration with Otto Hofstetter begin back in 1999?

My uncle picked up a catalogue from Otto Hofstetter AG at a trade fair in Taiwan. Following up on this first encounter, we were immediately impressed by the company's professional-



Long Thames prioritises quality over price, so it uses European machines and moulds to meet its demanding standards.



For employees, the company is not just a workplace, it's a big family.

ism and attention to detail. This led to us purchasing our first mould in Uznach in 1999. Back then, everything was still done via fax. That first project laid the foundation for the long-term partnership we have since built upon.

What advantages do you see in collaboration between family businesses?

I think the fact that we are both family-run companies explains why our partnership with Otto Hofstetter AG has endured for decades. This connects us through shared values such as a commitment to quality, a long-term perspective and making a priority of relationships built on trust. It feels less like a business relationship and more like family.

What has been your experience with Otto Hofstetter AG's moulds?

In 2024, we commissioned our sixth mould from the Uznach factory. While the initial investment was higher than some other options, the stability, durability and efficiency of these moulds

far outweigh their initial costs. Compared to competitors, the moulds deliver exceptional durability, reduced scrap and less downtime for maintenance. For us, Otto Hofstetter AG is an important partner that helps us maintain our customers' trust.

You completed an internship at Otto Hofstetter AG last year. What did you do?

Last year's internship was already my second in Uznach. I did my first internship in 2015, after completing my studies in Berlin. I spent two weeks in mould assembly, working on a 16-cavity cartridge mould.

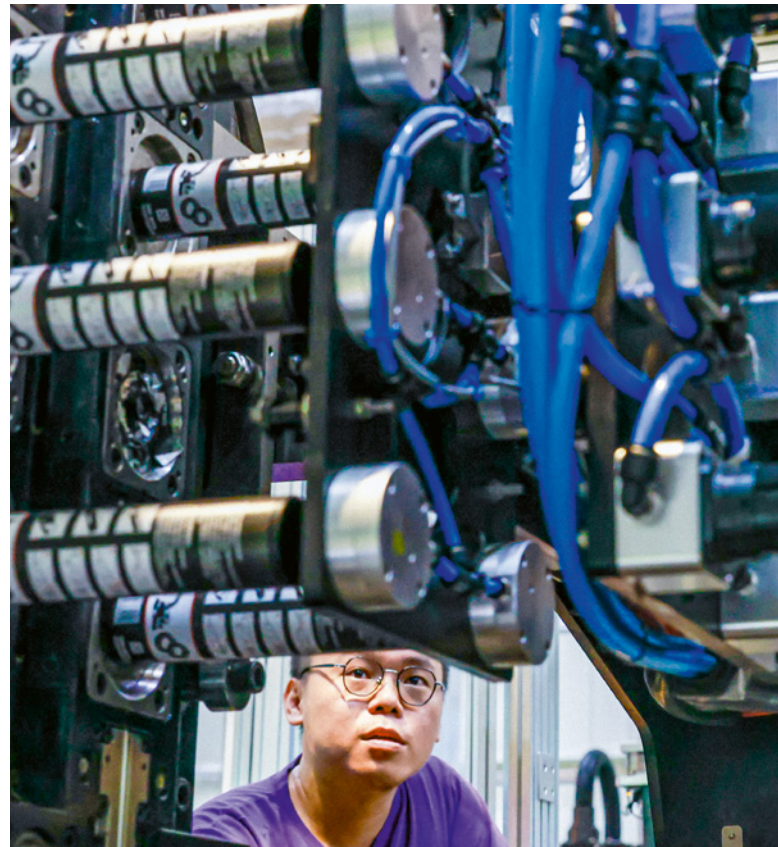
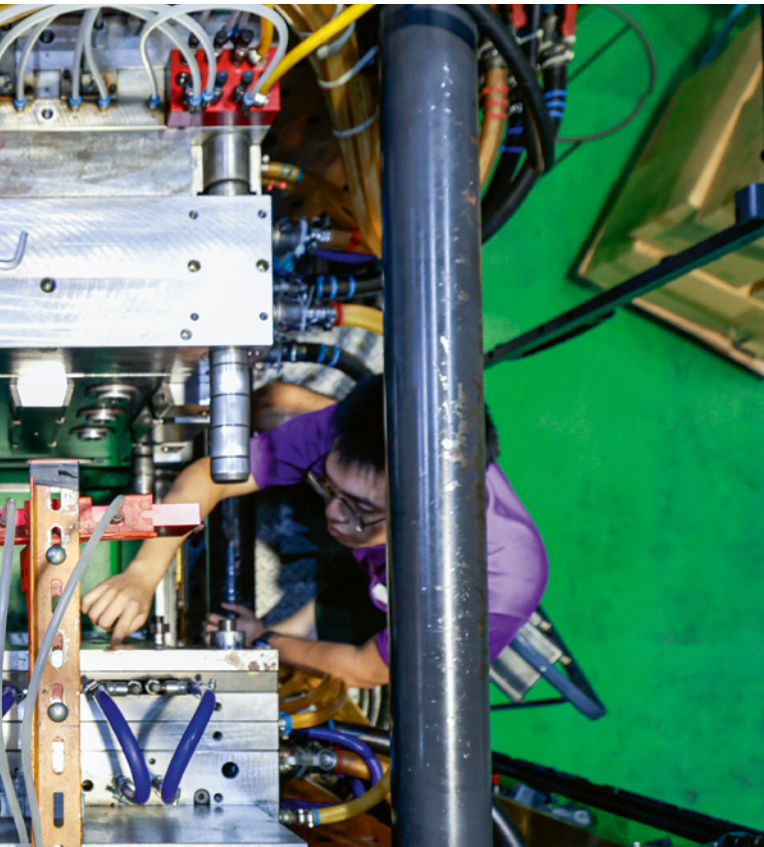
"THE COMBINATION OF DATA-DRIVEN METHODOLOGIES AND SOLID CRAFTSMANSHIP DEEPLY IMPRESSED ME AT OTTO HOFSTETTER AG."

David Chen, CEO of Long Thames Enterprise

What impressed you most about these experiences?

In Taiwan, many decisions are based on past experience, whereas at Otto Hofstetter AG, the results count most. The company relies on precise data for its analyses and decisions.

This data-driven approach enables consistently high quality. The combination of data-driven methodology and solid craftsmanship left a deep impression on me. During breaks, I sensed



For Long Thames, stability, durability and efficiency distinguish the moulds from Otto Hofstetter AG.

the close, harmonious relationships and the strong sense of belonging among the staff. This familial atmosphere strengthens team cohesion and resilience.

Where do you see potential for future collaboration?

Our collaboration with Otto Hofstetter AG has developed into a long-term, trust-based partnership. We see potential in three areas: new product development, talent development through technical exchanges and joint expansion into international markets.

How do you see the future of the industry and the role of Long Thames?

Sustainability, automation and the balance between globalisation and localisation will shape the future. Long Thames will act as a guarantor of quality, combining expertise from Taiwan with local US production.

Our approach follows the Taiwanese philosophy: just as my father and uncle never expected us to move to our current location, we never expected to have a location in the US. Success cannot be forced; we must allow it to happen. Running a business is like climbing a mountain: we work hard, take one

step at a time and eventually reach new heights. But that's not the end. We will continue to strive for ever higher peaks. In Taiwan, we have some of the longest working hours in the world, but for us, work means more than just earning money; it also means contributing to society as a whole.

Mr Chen, thank you very much for sharing your insights with us. We wish you and Long Thames all the best for the future and look forward to continuing our strong and fruitful cooperation.



Long Thames Enterprise
silicone-cartridge.com

Founded: 1971
Products: PE cartridges for silicone sealants and 400 g grease cartridges; caps and closures; scrapers and other plastic accessories
Locations: Production in Taiwan; supplying industrial customers worldwide

No. 300, Zhongxiao Rd., Bali District, 24944 New Taipei City, Taiwan

A photograph of two women in green vests and caps, likely waste collectors, walking through a rural area. One woman is carrying a large white bag of plastic waste. The background shows lush green trees and a blurred building. The image is framed by a large green circular graphic on the right side.

Closing the circle.

A year after its launch, the **Otto Systems Plastic Recovery Fund** has achieved **some impressive results**. Together with rePurpose Global and its local partner, **225,000 kilograms of plastic were collected** in 42 communities in rural **Kerala, India**. In addition, **1,500 jobs were created**. This project proves that the circular economy can work well when the necessary infrastructure is in place.



The plastics industry as a whole has achieved some remarkable results in applying the principles of the circular economy, and it continues to invest in this effort. That said, one aspect has often not been sufficiently considered globally. To reach its full potential, a smoothly functioning collection infrastructure is essential. Since May 2024, the Otto Systems Plastic Recovery Fund – the first of its kind from a systems engineering and mould manufacturer – has been addressing this bottleneck in India, where the Fund finances the decentralised collection, sorting and ethical processing of plastic waste.

Infrastructure makes the difference.

In the Fund's first twelve months, 225,000 kilograms of plastic waste were collected in 42 communities in rural Kerala. The collected plastic waste was processed according to rePurpose Global's "Verified Plastic Recovery" standards. This ensures complete traceability and prevents waste from continuing to be disposed of in the natural environment. Earlier this year, Otto Hofstetter and his wife Brigitt traveled to Kerala to visit the project on site and engage with local partners and residents.

In addition to collecting and processing a significant amount of plastic waste, the Fund supports important investments to improve infrastructure, building new material recovery facilities and installing mechanised sorting systems to further increase recycling capacity. This financing helped make the circular economy viable in locales where public solutions are limited or underfunded.

Social benefits included.

In addition to its environmental impact, the Fund also has a significant social impact, adding some 1,500 jobs to the community, 98 per cent of which are filled by women. These workers have permanent employment contracts and receive fair wages, safety equipment and proper training in various aspects of the recycling process. This combination of technical support and social impact demonstrates what's possible when the plastics industry goes beyond its traditional boundaries and invests where the need is greatest.

Join Otto Systems.

Customers of Otto Systems – Otto Hofstetter AG's sister company specialised in turnkey PET preform production systems – can support this project with their company. Their commitment to the Fund will be confirmed with a certificate, and data updates from the Kerala project will be provided. This allows the company's engagement to be integrated into its sustainability reporting and to be used in its communications.



rePurpose Global is the world's leading organisation combatting the unethical disposal of plastic. It works with companies, consumers and policymakers to meet the challenges of a circular plastics economy. The organisation operates in North and South America, Africa and Asia to empower local communities, protect ecosystems and promote the circular economy:

www.repurpose.global



With passion and determination.

Jogging through fields and forests, whatever the weather, is her absolute passion. Running gives her peace and clarity, which helps her in her work at Otto Hofstetter AG. **Andrea Kuster** has been with the company since 1991 and today primarily supports human resources and financial administration. However, she also steps in wherever her help is needed.

Andrea, you joined Otto Hofstetter AG in June 1991. What convinced you sign up back then?

I had completed my apprenticeship at Charles Vögele, a leading Swiss fashion retailer, and wanted to try something new. My mother told me about a job opening at Otto Hofstetter AG. Everyone in Uznach knew the Hofstetters, and I'd known Otto Hofstetter Junior since I was a child. He sometimes helped his wife, Brigitt, who coached the girls' gymnastics team that I belonged to. My mother also used to work as a cleaner at the company. The job description matched my educational profile, so I applied and got the position. It was a stroke of luck.

Going from fashion to mould making must have been a big change.

It was difficult at first. A completely different world. People spoke more directly than in the fashion business, where everything was more refined and reserved. Much of the production work at Otto Hofstetter AG was still done by hand; there were no robots. Nobody dared to even touch the computer. This was the era of the legendary Commodore computers, and we still recorded our working hours with classic paper time cards. Here's a little anecdote: Otto Junior had his office next to mine and it was always dangerous to step in there because he had a dartboard in his office and we never knew if darts were flying!

How big was the company back then?

Much smaller than today, probably fewer than 100 employees. In the back, where the new plant production building now stands, we had a football field where we often played and where we even had some fun tournaments, including us girls. That was a highlight. The design department, with the highly skilled technical draughtspeople at their large tables, sat where the sales department is today. Everything was much more cramped. Mr Hofstetter Senior was still the managing director and Otto Junior was the operations manager. Werni Hofstetter, Otto Senior's brother, was the accountant.

After eight years, you took a maternity leave and then decided to return.

I wasn't even gone a full year. My successor wanted to take an extended trip to Costa Rica and asked me if I would cover for her. My son was only six months old at the time and naturally he was fixated on me. I was offered the opportunity to come to the office whenever I wanted, as long as it suited my

responsibilities at home. This generosity and flexibility was also demonstrated in other contexts later on at the company. I think this kind of thing is only possible in a family business like Otto Hofstetter AG.

25 years have passed since you returned. What has changed? Everything has become much faster paced, on shorter notice and much more technical, sometimes almost too technical, ignoring the importance of personal relationships. But the employees have changed too. It seems to me that people used to be more aware of what a privilege it is to work at

Otto Hofstetter AG. Being able to work in such a fair and well-run company isn't something to take for granted these days. Perhaps it's because people used to be more dependent on their salary. Today, some people almost have too much.

"EVEN THOUGH WE NOW HAVE ALMOST 200 EMPLOYEES, THE COMPANY STILL VERY MUCH FEELS LIKE A FAMILY."

Andrea Kuster, Administration/HR team member

What's remained the same at the company?

The company still has a very family-like atmosphere. Everyone looks after each other. I started during Otto Hofstetter's Senior's time and he always had an ear open for his employees. It's the same with Otto Junior. With him, everyone gets a second chance. It only becomes difficult the third time around. The atmosphere among the staff is also friendly today, and everyone knows and greets each other, even though we now have almost 200 people in Uznach.

What moments in your career stand out for you?

My son Timo completed his apprenticeship as a polymechnic at Otto Hofstetter AG. That certainly was a highlight for me. My history with the company spans three generations of the Hofstetter family and that's also a very special thing. And here's a funny memory from a company outing, which we used to take regularly: everyone was waiting for the bus to pick us up but it never arrived. When we finally enquired with the driver, it turned out he had been booked for the following day. We all had a good laugh and made the trip the next day.

Are there any other memorable experiences?

For me, it's always a great moment when we open our company to the public or to other interested groups. When I think about where the company's roots lie and that we now operate in 77 countries, I'm filled with pride to be part of the company. And when I think back to the difficult moments – most recently the coronavirus pandemic – I realise that we have overcome



With Otto Hofstetter AG now operating in 77 countries, Andrea Kuster is proud to represent it.

some challenging times and always continued to work. In Otto Hofstetter Senior's time, it was a cardinal rule that before reducing anyone's working hours, he would find some way to keep us all employed, even cleaning the roof together, for example.

What does your daily routine look like?

You could call me a "jack of all trades", a role that I love. My responsibilities are very varied and range from time tracking and accounts payable management to travel visas for salespeople and service technicians so that they're always ready to work if needed. I also record production data, and in general if any kind of urgent situation develops, I'm ready to jump in and help out, if I have time.

"AT OTTO HOFSTETTER AG, CUSTOMERS, PARTNERS AND EMPLOYEES ARE NOT SIMPLY LEFT TO THEIR OWN DEVICES IF DIFFICULT SITUATIONS ARISE."

Andrea Kuster, Administration/HR team member

What are you particularly passionate about in your work?

I always make time for the company and especially for the apprentices. I'm like their House Mother and I really enjoy this role. Sometimes it's good for young people to get input from a neutral person. They know they can always turn to me – no matter what.

In your opinion, what's the basis for Otto Hofstetter AG's global success?

I think it's a combination of things: first the quality of our products, the many innovations we've introduced, the independence that comes from being a family-owned business, the character of both Otto Hofstetters, Senior and Junior, and the company's Swissness, by which I mean its emphasis on

quality and customer satisfaction. Innovation is driven by our customers' needs. And we don't shy away from challenges. For example, when the decades-long partnership with Netstal began to dissolve, Otto Systems was born. Perhaps our motto should be the old saying: if life gives you lemons, make lemonade!

How would you define the company's culture?

For one thing, in my experience, Otto Hofstetter AG would never abandon anyone who finds themselves in a difficult situation. This applies to customers and partners as well as to its employees. I am convinced that each individual employee makes an important contribution to the success of our company – regardless of their specific job. I seem to share this conviction with the management team. I also find our approach of taking time to learn about other points of view or the background that led to a specific decision or action is also a positive.

You are very athletic and run long distances. What drew you to this demanding hobby?

It started when I was ten or twelve years old. Today, you might say I was a child with ADHD, and running was my outlet. It's still like that today. If I'm worried about something, I go for a run for an hour. Afterwards, I usually find a new, more positive perspective. I also run because I want to stay healthy as I get older.

What running experience stands out in your memory?

I once saw a crime story about a runner who was attacked in the woods. When I went jogging the next morning, those images were still in my head. And suddenly, a man jumped out of the trees right in front of me. I screamed so loudly that he dropped the stick that he was holding. He was just a harmless mushroom picker. A completely different story has to do with a half marathon I signed up for. I was determined to run the course in 1:45, and I managed to do it. That showed me that if you really want to achieve something, you can.

What does nature mean for you?

Nature and fresh air are my sources of peace, reflection and clarity of mind. I love being outdoors. I usually go jogging or cycling alone. Even when my husband or daughter is with me, we don't talk much. If I see a deer, I consider it an emissary from heaven. When a butterfly flies by, I feel like one of my deceased loved ones is beside me. Nature means a lot to me.

What challenges do are coming your way in your job?

Our working lives will probably become ever more technical and digital. We may well also encounter programs that use AI in the areas of production figures and accounting. So, I hope

I don't miss the boat and can continue to contribute to the company's success. One task I set for myself is to convey to my trainees that they should passionate about the company and aware of their role as an ambassador for it.

How do you envision the company in ten years?

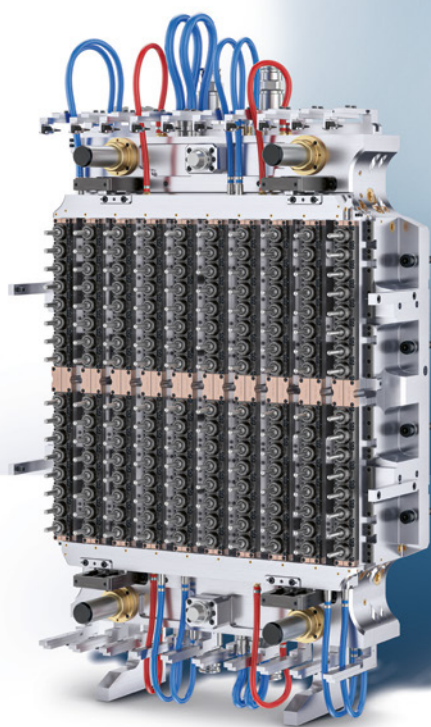
Ten years is a long time these days. It's really hard to imagine how things will look that far out into the future. But I believe we have every reason to be optimistic. I would be grateful if some things remain as they are on an interpersonal level. If there was still room for a joke or a chat after work. I think a feeling of togetherness, of being part of a team with a shared goal, will continue to be vital for the company's success.



Andrea Kuster

Andrea has worked at Otto Hofstetter AG for 34 years. Her various responsibilities include financial administration, operations management and HR. She balances her working life and her family life in nature – whatever the weather.

Light reveals
traditional Swiss
perfection.



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